

The 7-morning stiffness routine

Large print. One page a morning. Kettle on, joint warm, then the day.

This is the routine people tell us about, written down so you do not have to remember it. Seven mornings, one small thing each. By the end of the week it should feel like part of making the tea.

You will need: a kettle, a chair by a window, and half an hour you were going to spend sitting down anyway. If you have a Jointwell wrap, it goes on at the start. If you have a wheat bag, use that and notice when it goes cold. That is the point of morning three.

Nothing here is a treatment. Warmth and gentle movement are what the NHS and most physios suggest for stiff joints, and this is a way of doing them every day without a fuss.

Notice the first ten steps

Before you do anything else.

Out of bed, hand on the wall if you need it. Count the steps to the kettle. Notice which joint is deciding how you walk. That is your worst joint, and it gets the warmth this week.

Kettle on. Sit down. Warm the joint for the time it takes to drink the first cup. That is all for today.

Warm before you move

Not after.

A cold joint does not want to bend. A warm one is more willing. So the order is: warmth first, then the stairs, the dog, the garden. Never the other way round.

Wrap on, or wheat bag on, for twenty to thirty minutes with the first cup. Then stand up and take the same ten steps as yesterday. Notice the difference, if there is one.

Count the minutes it stays warm

The wheat bag test.

Whatever you are using, put a hand on it after ten minutes, then twenty. A wheat bag or hot water bottle is usually lukewarm by twenty. A joint needs about thirty minutes of steady warmth to loosen.

If yours went cold, you are not doing it wrong. The tool is. Warmth that holds is the whole difference.

Add three slow bends

Only as far as is comfortable.

With the joint warm, bend it slowly three times. Knee: sit, straighten the leg, lower it. Shoulder: reach for the top shelf and back. Elbow: open and close the hand, turn the wrist.

Stop if it hurts. Warm and gentle, never warm and forced. If you have a physio sheet, this is when to do it.

Do it in the chair you like

Not the one nearest the socket.

A routine survives if it is comfortable. Sit where you would sit anyway: by the window, with the paper, the crossword or the radio. If your warmth needs a wire, that is one more reason it gets skipped.

Half an hour. Tea, warmth, three slow bends. Then the day.

The evening go

For the days that were long.

Mornings are the main event, but a second half hour in the armchair after a day on your feet is what people tell us stops the next morning being a write-off. Wrap on with the television.

If the joint is hot, red or swollen after a hard day, that is an ice day instead, and worth a word with your GP if it keeps happening.

Keep it up when it is easy

This is the one that matters.

By now the joint may feel a bit better in the mornings, which is exactly when people stop. Do not. A routine managed twice a week does nothing. Every morning, with the first cup, whether it seems needed or not.

That is the routine. Kettle on, joint warm, three slow bends, then the day. Ninety mornings from now, you will know.